

“Our India business is not about milestones”

Prabhjeet Singh, President of Uber India and South Asia, talks about how the ride-hailing giant is moving towards profitability, helping drivers earn more, while focussing on its primary concern, the passengers

PHOTOS BY SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

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Marking a decade of operations in India, Uber is strategically broadening its service spectrum across cars, autorickshaws, two-wheelers and buses, along with intercity travel alternatives. This multi-mode approach is helping it retain customers within the platform, while offering users services at different price points. Concurrently, says Prabhjeet Singh, President of Uber India and South Asia, the company is actively engaged in initiatives to enhance drivers' earning opportunities in a fiercely competitive market like India. It involves an increased focus on CNG vehicles and transition to electric vehicles (EVs) that can help driver partners curtail operational costs. In an exclusive interview with *Business Today's Binu Paul*, Singh says there is still a lot more to do in India and the company is here to stay. Edited excerpts:

Q: In the past 10 years, how has Uber India established its position, both in the local market and within Uber's global operations?

A: We have seen India welcome us with open arms. We have built a very large business with a strong market leadership. We have done more than 3 billion trips to date here. Today, we have more than 800,000 active drivers, doing one to five trips each week. Our drivers have earned over ₹50,000 crore through the platform since 2013. Three million drivers have earned via the Uber app. We do much more than 500 million trips a year. And we are one of the fastest growing geographies for Uber at this scale.

We provide our services in 125 cities across the country. We provide services across a spectrum of two- and three-wheelers, cabs and buses. Globally, it is the third largest market on an absolute basis already, and growing rapidly. The India business has made massive strides towards being a very viable business, our economics have improved significantly. We feel very good about where we are headed.

Q: How significant has Uber's recovery been from the impact of the pandemic, in terms of operations and market position?

A: The pandemic obviously impacted mobility in a big way. However, we have grown significantly since then. Today, we are bigger than what we were on volume and value terms [pre-Covid-19]. All the categories are larger than what they were, especially Uber Moto and Auto, which shows there is a fundamental shift in passenger and driver behaviour.

Q: How does Dara Khosrowshahi (CEO of Uber) perceive the potential in the Indian